Blackford Physic Garden Trust · Living Collections Department

APIARY PLACEMENT PERMIT: GUIDE FOR APPLICANTS, 2027 SEASON

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Application form: AP-1
Version: 3

Hive Terrace Placement Scheme · 14 Cluny Lane, Edinburgh EH10 6DS · Issued 2 October 2026 · Applies to the season 20 March to 15 October 2027

1. PURPOSE OF THIS GUIDE

The Blackford Physic Garden Trust allows a limited number of private beekeepers to keep honey bee colonies on four hive stands inside the walled garden under its Hive Terrace Placement Scheme.

The guide is issued by Morag Lennie, Head of Living Collections, who signs every permit. Site visits and swarm calls are handled by Calum Imrie, Apiary Liaison Officer.

Application window	1 November 2026 to 15 January 2027 (17:00)
Decision letters sent	by 28 February 2027
Move-in window	20 March to 10 April 2027
Colonies removed by	15 October 2027

2. WHO MAY APPLY

Applicants must be at least 18 years old, live within 25 km of the garden, and have kept bees for at least two full seasons. Applicants with only one season of experience may apply if they name a mentor who holds a permit in the same season and who agrees in writing to supervise inspections. Each applicant may hold one permit and place colonies on one stand only.

- Public liability insurance covering beekeeping with a minimum cover of **£5 million** per claim. Until the 2026 season the minimum was £2 million; certificates at the old level are no longer accepted.
- A colony health certificate signed by a qualified bee health inspector, dated no more than 30 days before the colonies arrive.

3. HIVE STANDS AND COLONY CAPACITY

The number of colonies a stand can take depends on the flowering area that bees from the stand can use. Forage inside the garden counts in full; open green space outside the walls within 1 km (Blackford Hill, the Hermitage of Braid) counts at 30 % because it is shared with other apiaries. The capacity of each stand is set with equation (1).

$$H_{max} = \left\lfloor \frac{A_s + 0.3 \times A_n}{a} \right\rfloor \qquad (1)$$

where H_{max} is the maximum number of colonies on the stand, A_s the flowering area inside the garden assigned to the stand (ha), A_n the green space outside the walls within 1 km of the stand (ha), a the forage area required per colony, set at 0.9 ha from the 2027 season (it was 1.2 ha until 2026), and $\lfloor\ \rfloor$ means rounding down to a whole colony.

Worked example, Stand B (Orchard Bank): A_s = 2.3 ha and A_n = 5.0 ha. The weighted area is 2.3 + 0.3 × 5.0 = 3.8 ha; 3.8 / 0.9 = 4.22, rounded down to **4 colonies**.

Capacities for the 2027 season:

- **Stand A, Rock Garden Terrace**: A_s 1.6 ha, A_n 3.5 ha, capacity 2 colonies.
- **Stand B, Orchard Bank**: A_s 2.3 ha, A_n 5.0 ha, capacity 4 colonies.

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- **Stand C, Heath Garden North**: A_s 1.1 ha, A_n 8.2 ha, capacity 3 colonies.
- **Stand D, Nursery Yard**: A_s 0.8 ha, A_n 2.0 ha, capacity 1 colony; reserved for applicants with one season of experience and their mentors.

No stand may hold more than 6 colonies in any case, and nucleus colonies of five frames or fewer count as half a colony.

4. CALCULATING THE PERMIT FEE

The permit fee is made up of a non-refundable application fee and a colony charge for each month a colony is on site. Any part of a calendar month counts as a full month. The fee is calculated with equation (2).

$$F = F_0 + c \times h \times m \times \left(1 - \delta\right) \tag{2}$$

where F is the total permit fee (£), F_0 the application fee of £60 (it was £45 for the 2026 season), c the colony charge of £4.80 per colony per month, h the number of full colonies on the permit, m the number of months on site, and δ the discount rate: 0.25 for Trust volunteers who logged at least 40 volunteer hours between 1 October 2025 and 30 September 2026, 0.50 for students enrolled on the Trust's Certificate in Garden Beekeeping, and 0 for everyone else. The discount applies to the colony charge only, and the two discounts cannot be combined; the higher one is used.

Worked example: a beekeeper with no discount keeps 2 colonies on Stand C from 20 April to 30 September 2027, which is 6 months (April to September). F = 60 + 4.80 × 2 × 6 × (1 − 0) = 60 + 57.60 = **£117.60**.

The colony charge is invoiced with the decision letter and must be paid within 14 days, otherwise the offer lapses.

5. SITING DISTANCE FROM PUBLIC PATHS

Hives on a stand must be set back from the nearest path open to the public. The minimum distance is set with equation (3).

$$d_{min} = 3 + 1.2 \times h_s \tag{3}$$

where d_{min} is the minimum distance in metres between the front of the nearest hive and the edge of the nearest public path, and h_s the total number of colonies on the stand from all permit holders together (a nucleus counts as 0.5).

Worked example: Stand B with 4 colonies needs d_{min} = 3 + 1.2 × 4 = **7.8 m**.

Screen exception. Where a solid fence, wall or dense hedge at least 2.0 m high stands between the hives and the path along the whole stand, the distance from equation (3) is halved. The halved distance may never be less than 3.0 m. Stands A and C have qualifying walls; Stands B and D do not.

6. COLONY HEALTH AND DISEASE RULES

All colonies must be inspected by the permit holder at least every 10 days from the start of May to the end of July, and at least every 21 days at other times of the season. Varroa mite levels must be monitored once a month using a sticky board or an alcohol wash, and logged.

Colonies may not be brought on site if they come from an apiary within 5 km of a confirmed case of American or European foulbrood in the previous 12 months, unless the colonies have had two clear inspections by a qualified bee health inspector at least 6 weeks apart, the second one no more than 30 days before arrival. Suspected foulbrood or any other notifiable pest found on site

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must be reported to the Apiary Liaison Officer the same day; the Trust will then close the stand to all colony moves until it is cleared in writing by an inspector.

Syrup feeders must be inside the hive; open feeding is not allowed.

7. WORKING ON SITE

Permit holders may enter the garden through the service gate on Cluny Lane between 07:00 and 09:30, and after 17:30 until dusk, using the key fob issued with the permit. Hive inspections are not allowed while the garden is open to visitors, except for swarm control on Stand D.

When a swarm is reported, the permit holder must arrive within 2 hours; otherwise a £35 call-out charge is added to the next invoice.

8. HONEY AND THE TRUST'S SHARE

Honey belongs to the permit holder, but the Trust keeps a share of the surplus above a basic yield per colony. The Trust's share is set with equation (4) and is due by 31 October 2027.

$$S = 0.12 \times max(0,\, Y - 9 \times h) \qquad (4)$$

where S is the Trust's share of honey (kg), Y the total weight of honey extracted from the permit holder's colonies in the season (kg), h the number of colonies on the permit, and 9 kg the basic yield per colony that the permit holder keeps in full.

Worked example: 3 colonies yield Y = 58 kg in total. The surplus is 58 − 27 = 31 kg, so S = 0.12 × 31 = **3.72 kg**. It may be paid in cash at £14 per kg instead (here £52.08). A permit holder whose total yield is 9 kg per colony or less owes nothing.

9. SELECTION, BREACHES AND WITHDRAWAL

If a stand receives more requests than its capacity, places are offered in this order: first, holders of a 2026 permit with no recorded breach; second, Trust volunteers who qualify for the 0.25 discount; third, all other applicants, by a ballot held on 3 February 2027 in the Garden Office.

A breach is any of: missing a required inspection interval twice; two missed swarm calls; open feeding; an inspection while the garden is open (other than on Stand D); or failing to report suspected foulbrood the same day. One breach leads to a written warning. A second breach in the same season ends the permit, and colonies must be removed within 7 days.

Withdrawal and refunds. A permit holder who removes colonies voluntarily and tells the Apiary Liaison Officer in writing before 1 July 2027 receives a refund of the colony charge for each full month remaining. No refund is given for removals notified on or after 1 July 2027, or when a permit ends because of breaches. Where the Trust closes a stand for disease, the colony charge for the months the stand is closed is refunded in full, whatever the date. The application fee is never refunded.

10. BEFORE YOU SUBMIT FORM AP-1

□ Form AP-1 completed, naming one preferred stand and one alternative
□ Copy of public liability insurance certificate (minimum £5 million)
□ Application fee of £60 paid

Enquiries: Calum Imrie, Apiary Liaison Officer, Garden Office, room G.04, telephone 0131 496 0732.

Applicant signature and date	Morag Lennie, Head of Living Collections

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